

Differing Perceptions

The voter perceptions at the national and state levels vary vastly. For example Mayawati ranked second nationally but stood 17th when gauged at the state level.

National Ranking State Ranking

NARENDRA MODI	1	2
MAYAWATI	2	17
Y.S.R. REDDY	3	5
NITISH KUMAR	4	3
SHEILA DIKSHIT	5	14
M. KARUNANIDHI	6	7
VILASRAO DESHMUKH	7	10
B. BHATTACHARYA	8	16
VASUNDHARA RAJE	9	7
RAMAN SINGH	10	11
NAVEEN PATNAIK	11	9
PARKASH S. BADAL	12	4
TARUN KUMAR GOGOI	13	15
B.S. HOODA	14	18
MADHU KODA	15	19
V.S. ACHUTHANANDAN	16	13
SHIVRAJ CHAUHAN	17	6
B.C. KHANDURI	18	1

Methodology

The poll sample covered 12,492 voters of 98 parliamentary constituencies in 19 states, spread across urban, rural areas and comprising both males and females in different age groups. Apart from their opinion on who they thought was the best chief minister, voters were also asked to rate the performance of the chief ministers of their respective states. Not surprisingly, while voters backed their own chief minister at the national level, they were meaner while assessing their work within the state.

larger numbers of voters in other states too believe Modi is on the right path. In Delhi where Sheila Dikshit could garner just 43 per cent of the votes, "outsider" Modi was considered the best by 31 per cent of the voters. In Andhra Pradesh and Delhi, two states on the fast growth track, 68 and 57 per cent, respectively, believed that by voting for him in last year's assembly elections, voters in Gujarat had given a thumbs up to Modi's development agenda. In contrast, those who thought the vote was for aggressive Hindutva were a minuscule 2 per cent in Andhra Pradesh and 20 per cent in Delhi. If the managers of BJP's election campaign in poll-bound Karnataka are in search of some good news, here it is: 35 per cent of the state's voters think Modi is the best chief minister. May be the state BJP unit should ask him to lead the campaign on behalf of the party. Though small, it is significant that he evokes a positive response among sections even in red West Bengal and Kerala and Ram-bashing Tamil Nadu, something even the formidable Mayawati has not been able to achieve despite her recent pan-Indian exertions aimed at spreading BSP credo.

More than 10 states are due for assembly elections this year, the results of which will be seen as a barometer for the Lok Sabha polls which must be held before April 2009. Dikshit occupied the number one slot in our polls three years ago, but has slipped to the fifth place in national rankings this time. Worse, with the voters of her state giving her a net popularity rating (NPR) of 26, she is ranked as low as 14th among the 19 chief ministers surveyed. Among all the ministers heading for polls, her tally is one of the lowest. This is not to suggest that her counterparts in other states are going to have an easy stroll back to power. Voters in Maharashtra, Orissa and Jharkhand seem less satisfied with their chief ministers Vilasrao Deshmukh, Naveen Patnaik and Madhu Koda than they were a year ago, while the reverse is the case in Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan. The dumper scandal involving his wife seems to have had little effect on the public's perception of Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chauhan, while Vasundhara Raje, among the grittiest to have occupied the chief minister's chair in Jaipur, has won the voters' backing for her administrative acumen and tenacity.

The picture at the national and state level appears mixed. Uttarakhand's B.C. Khanduri comes 18th nationally while stands first at the state level and Mayawati who is ranked second at the national level is a lowly 17th at the state level. There are exceptions though. Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, ranked first two years ago, has slipped to the eighth place nationally and with an NPR of 20, he stands 16th at the state level. West Bengal obviously is not ready to be reformed.

with Priya Verma

With anti incumbency on the rise as polls near, some chief ministers may find the going tough.